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R. V. MOORTHY

Table-topper Punjab has been the most successful in executing this approach. While the top three score at over 12 an over, numbers four and five go at 11.1, and the lower middle order (6-8) at 10.81.

"If you look at the way we've played, our top order has been super dynamic. They've set up games and created opportunities," Haddin said.

"But what the rest have done is contribute in roles that win matches. It might not be a 70 or 80; it could be 15 off six balls to give us momentum. At the moment, they're doing everything the game

requires."

Sandeep, however, believes finishers remain vital, especially over a long tournament.

"I don't think the importance of finishers has reduced at all. Teams with strong finishers still have a great chance. If you look at the past, Chennai had Mahi *bhai* (M.S. Dhoni, **above left**), Mumbai had Hardik Pandya (**above right**) and Kieron Pollard, KKR had Andre Russell. Teams with strong players at 5, 6, and 7 tend to go far. That's where the bulk of pressure lies. The top three don't carry as much pressure. If they get out playing positively, it's

accepted. But 5-6-7 is a crucial phase," he said.

This season has still produced instances of lower-order influence, such as Rinku Singh's unbeaten 83 in Kolkata Knight Riders' eventual Super Over win against Lucknow Super Giants. However, those moments are becoming rarer in a league where the PowerPlay is fast becoming the new death overs, and openers the new finishers.

Stats updated till Match 42 (GT vs RCB)

Matches not included - KKR vs PBKS - Washout and RR vs MI - Rain-affected games, PP reduced.